so grown turns out to be less than the rice, wheat or maize crop, it might hurt both the farmer and the country. India does not have a comparative advantage in growing edible oilseeds over cereals. Therefore, if the policy of becoming atmanirbhar is stretched to every crop, it might end up adversely affecting the country.

The case of considering comparative advantage in manufactured products is more complicated as technology and innovation have become more powerful factors than labour and land in case of manufactured products.

The lessons from the last seventy-five years of India's experience of fiddling with the policy of import substitution and self-reliance have taught us much.

First, the policy of import substitution and self-reliance is self-defeating. It ends up making agriculture inefficient and manufacturing obsolete.

Second, product by product self-reliance is not a good policy. It puts you in a vicious circle where you might end up achieving self-reliance in a targeted product but something else would give in or come at a greater overall cost.

Third, the policy of import substitution and self-reliance leads to the adoption of inefficient policies of creating tariff walls, imposing physical controls on imports of certain products and using instruments like anti-dumping too frequently. All these lead to trapping the economy in non-competitiveness and unproductive manufacturing.

Fourth, there is a much better option of increasing competitive advantage in select products to make overall balance of payments more favourable to India, which is actually true self-reliance.